
LOVEBIRD

Agapornis spp.



Intermediate

Complete Care Package

Quick Profile · Care Guide · Health · Quick Reference · Owner Tools

BeastlyFacts

Practical care guides for curious animal lovers

Contents

How to Use This Package

How to read this manual and which pages to print first

1. Quick Profile

Species overview, fact table, fun facts, and cost range

2. Full Care Guide

Cage, diet, handling, enrichment, common mistakes

3. Health & Common Issues

Egg binding, respiratory, PBFD, red flags

4. Quick Reference & Checklist

Setup checklist and targets

Emergency & Quick Targets

One-page emergency card to post near the cage

5. Owner Tools & Decision Guides

Budget, shopping list, first 30 days, symptoms, daily routine

Owner Log

Weight and daily tracking tables

Enrichment Checklist

Setup and monthly enrichment review

Glossary

Key terms in plain language

How to Use This Package

This is a practical manual, not a textbook. Use the Quick Profile for orientation, the Care Guide for day-to-day husbandry, and Health when something looks wrong. Owner Tools are designed to print and post near the cage.

This package is for educational purposes and is not a substitute for veterinary care. Birds hide illness until late - when in doubt, contact an avian veterinarian.

Print these first

- Symptom quick reference (Health) - page 7
- Setup checklist and targets (Quick Reference) - page 8
- Emergency card - page 9
- Shopping list and budget tiers (Owner Tools) - page 10
- First 30 days checklist - page 10
- Daily and weekly routine - page 11

1. Quick Profile

Lovebirds (*Agapornis* spp.) are small, energetic African parrots famous for strong pair bonds. The peach-faced lovebird (*A. roseicollis*) is the most common pet species. They are bold, often territorial, and need either a compatible partner or substantial daily human interaction. Intermediate difficulty comes mainly from behavioral intensity, hormonal management in hens, and the need for proper diet and enrichment.

Native Range	Africa and Madagascar (species-dependent)
Natural Habitat	Savanna, open woodland, forest edge
Adult Size	5-6.5 in (13-17 cm); about 1.5-2 oz
Wild Diet	Seeds, grains, berries, grasses, some insects
Typical Lifespan	5-15 years; 15-20 possible with excellent care
Conservation	Most species Least Concern; Fischer's Near Threatened
Difficulty	Intermediate
Temperament	Bonded, bold, can be territorial; pair or heavy human time

Fun Facts

- Bonded pairs spend long stretches preening each other and sitting pressed side-by-side - the behavior that earned the common name.
 - Hens can lay eggs without a male present. Chronic laying and egg binding are real risks that diet and lighting help prevent.
 - A single lovebird often redirects all pair-bond behavior onto its person and needs several hours of daily interaction to stay mentally healthy.
-

Cost Overview

Plan for a larger starter cage than many pet stores suggest - 24x24x24 inches minimum, with 30x24x30 or larger preferred. Quality pellets, destructible toys that will be replaced, and a proper travel carrier add to the upfront cost. Bigger space is almost always the better investment.

Monthly food is moderate. Budget for an avian wellness exam and an emergency fund. Pairs double food cost but often improve welfare when truly compatible. Hormonal and egg-binding emergencies are expensive - prevention through diet, consistent sleep, and avoiding nest triggers is cheaper than crisis care.

2. Full Care Guide

Housing & Cage

Minimum often cited is about 24x24x24 inches; 30x24x30 or larger is preferred. Width matters - lovebirds fly more horizontally than vertically. Bar spacing about 1/2 inch. Provide multiple perches of different diameters and textures (natural wood preferred). Place the cage at eye level, away from kitchens, drafts, and direct harsh sun, with a wall behind for security. Leave open wing-stretch space - do not fill every inch with toys.



Example lovebird cage layout (BeastlyFacts tank setup guide).

Diet & Feeding

Aim for about 60-70% high-quality small-parrot pellets. Offer fresh vegetables daily (bell peppers, leafy greens, broccoli, carrots, cooked sweet potato, snap peas). Seeds belong as enrichment inside foraging toys, not as the primary diet - seed-only feeding drives fatty liver and deficiencies. Millet is a treat only. Avoid avocado, chocolate, caffeine, onion, garlic, and xylitol. Fresh water daily.

Handling & Social Needs

Lovebirds form intense bonds. A compatible pair provides constant social enrichment; a single bird will often attach to a person and needs several hours of daily interaction to stay mentally healthy. Respect body language (eye pinning, lunging, fluffing). Do not reach into the cage when the bird is in a territorial mood. Provide 1-2+ hours of supervised out-of-cage time in a bird-safe space. Introduce second birds only with a slow, careful process - forced pairings fail.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- **Never** rely on an all-seed diet.
 - **Never** ignore chronic egg-laying triggers (nest boxes, long daylight, mirrors) in hens.
 - **Never** treat egg binding as wait-and-see - it is an emergency.
 - **Never** keep a single lovebird without either a partner or heavy daily interaction.
 - **Never** mix lovebirds casually with other parrot species in one cage.
 - **Never** skip avian veterinary care for respiratory signs or sudden behavior collapse.
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Enrichment

Lovebirds are busy, intense small parrots. In the wild they spend long hours flying, foraging, chewing nesting material, and interacting with a partner. An open food dish and a static cage leave excess energy that often turns into screaming, aggression, or feather damage. Enrichment has to match that intensity.

Foraging Enrichment

Begin with easy wins: treats or a few pellets under crumpled paper, inside a paper cup, or tucked into a cardboard tube. Progress to small foraging cups, treat balls, and simple puzzles sized for lovebirds - not large-parrot hardware. Scatter a portion of the daily ration or clip leafy greens into the bars. Rotate foraging devices every few days; once a mechanism is mastered it loses value. Match difficulty to the individual.

Chewing, Shredding & Nesting Drive

Lovebirds have a powerful drive to shred and collect material. Channel it into soft wood, balsa, palm, sola, seagrass, plain cardboard, and paper-based shredders. Replace toys as they are destroyed. Be cautious with deep nest boxes or tent-like hideaways for hens if chronic egg-laying is a problem - those can stimulate reproductive behavior. Avoid toys that fray into long threads or contain toxic metals.

Perches, Climbing & Cage Zoning

Choose the largest practical cage with more width than height when possible. Provide multiple perches of different diameters and textures (natural wood preferred). Include a swing, ladder, or rope for movement between zones. Leave open space so the bird can stretch wings without constantly dodging toys. Zone the cage: hanging foragers and swings higher, chew toys mid-level, foot toys or trays lower.

Social Needs & Rotation

Lovebirds form strong pair bonds. A compatible pair supplies constant social enrichment; a single bird requires several hours of daily human interaction. Keep a larger toy collection and rotate 3-5 items into the cage every few days to weekly. Supervised out-of-cage time on a play stand adds flight and exploration. Positive-reinforcement training improves handling and gives the bird a job. If a hen begins chronic egg-laying, reduce nest-like cavities, keep a consistent 10-12 hour dark period, and consult an avian veterinarian.

3. Health & Common Issues

Lovebird health problems often track diet, hormones, and infectious disease. Chronic egg-laying and egg binding are major risks in hens. Respiratory disease (including zoonotic psittacosis) needs prompt care. PBFD is serious and contagious. Birds hide illness - sudden changes matter.

Red Flags - Contact an Avian Vet Promptly

- Straining, lethargy, abdominal swelling (egg binding - emergency)
- Wheezing, breathing difficulty, nasal discharge
- Constantly fluffed, appetite loss, sitting low on the perch
- Sudden feather loss, deformities, or beak changes (PBFD concern)
- Severe feather plucking with skin damage
- Any sudden collapse in activity or strength

Tell the vet diet, daylight schedule, nest access, egg history, and when signs started. Find an avian vet before you need one.

Symptom Quick Reference

Sign	Possible concern	Action
Straining, swollen abdomen	Egg binding	Emergency avian vet
Wheeze / hard breathing	Respiratory disease	Avian vet ASAP
Fluffed, low energy, no appetite	Serious illness	Avian vet within 24h
Feather/beak deformities	Possible PBFD	Avian vet; isolate

Chronic Egg-Laying & Egg Binding

Hens can lay without a male. Seed-heavy diets low in calcium and vitamin D raise risk. Egg binding (straining, lethargy, swollen abdomen) is an emergency. Prevention: pelleted diet with proper calcium, consistent 10-12 hours of darkness, and avoiding nest boxes or mirrors if laying is a problem.

PBFD (Psittacine Beak and Feather Disease)

A viral disease that can cause feather deformities, feather loss, beak abnormalities, and immune suppression. Often fatal; highly contagious to other parrots. Test new birds before introduction when possible.

Respiratory Disease

Wheezing, discharge, and labored breathing need prompt avian care. Psittacosis is zoonotic - people can get it. Mention respiratory signs, diarrhea, and weakness to the vet.

4. Quick Reference & Checklist

Essential setup checklist

- Cage at least 24x24x24 in (30x24x30+ better); bar spacing ~1/2 in
 - Multiple natural-wood perches of varied diameter
 - Pellet-based diet + daily vegetables
 - Foraging and destructible chew toys with rotation plan
 - Consistent 10-12 hour dark/sleep period
 - Bird-safe room for 1-2+ hours out-of-cage time
 - Pair plan OR scheduled multi-hour human interaction
 - No casual mixed-species housing
 - Avian veterinarian identified
-

Quick targets

Target	Value
Cage minimum	24x24x24 in; larger preferred
Bar spacing	~1/2 inch
Diet base	60-70% quality small-parrot pellets
Sleep / darkness	10-12 hours consistent
Out-of-cage time	1-2+ hours daily supervised

Emergency & Quick Targets - Lovebird

Print this page and keep it near the enclosure. When something looks wrong, start here.

Quick Targets

Parameter	Target
Cage minimum	24x24x24 in; 30x24x30+ preferred
Bar spacing	1/2 inch
Diet base	60-70% quality small-parrot pellets
Darkness / sleep	10-12 hours covered, consistent
Out-of-cage time	1-2+ hours daily supervised

Red Flags - Act Early

- Straining, lethargy, abdominal swelling (egg binding emergency)
 - Wheezing, breathing difficulty, nasal discharge
 - Fluffed constantly, appetite loss, sitting low on perch
 - Sudden feather loss, deformities, or beak changes (PBFD concern)
 - Severe feather plucking with skin damage
 - Any sudden behavior collapse or weakness
-

Do This Now

- Egg binding or breathing distress - same-day avian vet
 - Note diet, daylight hours, nest access, and recent egg history
 - Do not pull an egg or force handling if bird is straining
-

Full symptom triage table (sign → concern → action) is in **3. Health & Common Issues**.

5. Owner Tools & Decision Guides

Budget tiers (approximate, single bird)

Tier	Upfront	What you get
Functional	\$120-180	24x24x24 cage, basic perches, dishes, starter pellets/toys
Recommended	\$180-300	Larger cage, natural perches, full toy set, scale, carrier
Premium	\$300-450+	30x24x30+ cage, play gym, toy rotation stock, first avian visit

Monthly food is moderate. Budget for avian wellness care and an emergency fund. Pairs double food cost. Hormonal and egg-binding emergencies are expensive - prevention is cheaper.

Shopping List

- Cage at least 24x24x24 in (30x24x30+ preferred); bar spacing ~1/2 in
 - Multiple natural-wood perches of varied diameter and texture
 - Food and water dishes (ceramic or stainless preferred)
 - High-quality small-parrot pellets (main diet)
 - Limited seed for foraging toys only (not open-dish staple)
 - Foraging toys sized for small parrots (cups, paper wraps, simple puzzles)
 - Destructible chew/shred toys (soft wood, palm, cardboard) - plan to replace
 - Swing and/or ladder
 - Cage cover for consistent 10-12 hour dark/sleep schedule
 - Play gym or out-of-cage stand
 - Travel carrier
 - Digital scale (grams) for weight checks
 - Budget for initial avian wellness exam
 - Avoid nest boxes if chronic egg-laying is a concern
-

First 30 Days

- Days 1-3: Quiet settling. Offer pellets and familiar food; begin gentle vegetable introductions. Minimal forced handling.
- Days 4-7: Short training sessions (target or step-up). Confirm droppings and appetite are normal. Start simple foraging.
- Week 2: Establish out-of-cage routine in a bird-safe room. Rotate one toy. Weigh and log baseline.
- Week 3-4: Full daily routine. Book or confirm avian wellness visit. Assess whether a companion is planned.

Daily & Weekly Routine

Print this page and post it near the cage. Check boxes as you go. Use the date lines to track consistency.

Daily

- Fresh water; refresh pellets and vegetables
 - Visual check (posture, droppings, breathing, activity)
 - Foraging opportunity and/or chew toy access
 - Social time (pair interaction or human session)
 - Supervised out-of-cage time when schedule allows
 - Consistent lights-out for 10-12 hour sleep
-

Weekly

- Wash dishes and wipe cage bars/perches
 - Replace destroyed shreddables; rotate 1-2 toys
 - Weigh bird and log the number
 - Change cage paper / substrate
 - Inspect feet, cere, and vent
-

Monthly / ongoing

- Deep-clean cage and accessories
- Review weight trend and diet balance
- Confirm avian vet contact is current
- Reassess hormonal triggers if hen is laying

Week of: _____ Initials: _____

Week of: _____ Initials: _____

Week of: _____ Initials: _____

Owner Log - Lovebird

Track weight and basic daily notes. Weight change is often the earliest warning sign. Print extra copies as needed.

Weight & Daily Log

Date	Weight (g)	Ate?	Eggs?	Notes

Egg-Laying & Hormonal Notes

- Chronic egg-laying and egg binding are common and dangerous. Use pellets with proper calcium, keep a consistent 10-12 hour dark period, and avoid nest boxes/mirrors if hens keep laying.
- Egg binding (straining, lethargy, swollen abdomen) is an emergency - same-day avian care.
- Psittacosis is zoonotic; report respiratory signs promptly.
- Find an avian veterinarian before you need one.

Enrichment Checklist - Lovebird

Enrichment is not optional decoration. Use this as a setup and monthly review checklist.

Setup & Ongoing Checklist

- Daily foraging cups, paper wraps, and treat puzzles sized for small parrots
- Destructible chew/shred toys (soft wood, palm, cardboard) replaced as used
- Wide cage with varied natural perches and open wing-stretch space
- Swing, ladder, and zoned toy placement without overcrowding
- Rotate 3-5 toys weekly from a larger set
- Compatible pair OR several hours of daily human interaction
- Supervised out-of-cage flight/play time
- Avoid nest boxes if chronic egg-laying is a problem

Monthly review notes (write in):

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Rule: stability for core hides/heat/water systems; novelty only in non-critical items.

Glossary

Egg binding. Egg stuck in the reproductive tract; life-threatening emergency.

Eye pinning. Rapid shrinking/expanding of the pupil - arousal, which can mean excitement or aggression.

PBFD. Psittacine Beak and Feather Disease - contagious viral disease of parrots.

Psittacosis. Chlamydia psittaci infection; can pass between birds and people.

Foraging. Working to find and extract food - essential captive enrichment.

Pair bond. Strong social attachment typical of lovebirds; drives much of their behavior.

This care package was compiled from BeastlyFacts research and practical husbandry standards.

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Disclaimer: This package is for educational purposes and is not a substitute for veterinary care. Husbandry standards evolve; always verify critical health decisions with a qualified avian veterinarian.

No external links are included in this document.
